

A YEAR AFTER Ritwik Sen (name changed) joined a multinational telecom services company in a management role, he was asked by the company to enrol in a sponsored six-month management course on leadership offered through an edtech firm. Sen, who has an MCA degree and 12 years of work experience, was told that this would help him get promoted.

Sen, who is undergoing the course at present, says the curriculum is designed with video lectures and assignments and covers topics like communication skills, leadership skills, problem solving, agility, etc.

Sen's experience bears testament to the now established trend of continuous learning for working professionals as companies look to upskill existing employees to keep pace with the ever-changing requirements of the dynamic workplace.

Of course, individuals too are joining MBA courses offered by edtech companies in partnership with established colleges as they try to catch the changing tides of the new workplace in the hopes that it will lead them to fortune.

In the case of individuals, they are often enticed by the prospect of gaining a degree from a global university for a fraction of what a normal MBA programme would cost. Besides, they can do it all from the comfort of their homes.

Numbers are hard to come by in this relatively new segment, but edtech companies say that there certainly isn't any dip in demand. Anecdotal evidence from working professionals, too, indicates that they are willing to join such courses in light of the deep uncertainty that has set in over the past few years, with the increasing preponderance of technologies like artificial intelligence raising concerns of redundancies.

These courses have also received a boost with the University Grants Commission (UGC) allowing top-ranked autonomous colleges, recognised in the National Institutional Ranking Framework (NIRF), or institutions with high grades from the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC), to offer full-degree programmes online without needing prior approval.

But as the initial enthusiasm has subsided, the question that is being asked with increasing frequency is if these courses match up to the traditional offline ones. This comes at a time when placements even at reputed B-schools have slowed and salary packages have become thinner.

That is where the two tracks seem to be diverging—recruiters aren't rushing to hire people who do

WHAT'S COOKING?



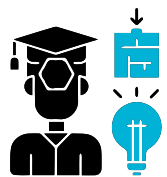
EDTECH MBA COURSES TOOK OFF IN RECENT YEARS, SPURRED BY THE LEISURE TIME ON OFFER DURING THE PANDEMIC AND THE THREAT OF JOB LOSS DUE TO TECHNOLOGICAL CHANGE



ANOTHER REASON WAS THAT UNLIKE OFFLINE MBA COURSES THAT START AT ₹16 LAKH, THESE COURSES CAN BE DONE FOR AS LOW AS ₹1 LAKH



THESE COURSES ALSO HOLD THE PROMISE OF CAREER PROGRESSION AND MOST PROVIDERS CLAIM THAT THE COMPLETION OF THEIR COURSES LEADS TO A SIGNIFICANT INCREMENT



EXPERTS SAY THE CURRENT TREND IS INCLINED TOWARDS SKILLS-BASED TRAINING, WITH A STRONG DEMAND FOR THE MANAGEMENT COURSES, ESPECIALLY EXECUTIVE COURSES



ONLINE COURSES HAVE ALSO RECEIVED A FILLIP THANKS TO GOVERNMENT POLICY, LIKE WITH THE NATIONAL EDUCATION POLICY THAT SAYS TRADITIONAL INSTITUTES CAN OFFER UP TO 30-40% OF THEIR COURSE CURRICULUM ONLINE